

Directory

Pérotin

ACTIVE c. 1200, FRENCH

Pérotin is an extremely obscure figure, but the vague and scant information that survives about him in late- 13th-century sources suggests that he was one of the most significant musicians of his time. His name means little Peter or Pierre and he is sometimes known by the Latin form, Perotinus. He is thought to have worked at Notre-Dame Cathedral, Paris, and all his music is religious. He seems to have been one of the most important pioneers of polyphony: that is, music in which several melodic lines are used simultaneously and either blend or weave in and out harmoniously. Earlier sacred works had sometimes used a plainchant melody sung against another melodic line, but Pérotin composed pieces in three and four parts. This is regarded as one of the most significant developments in Western music.

KEY WORKS: Viderunt omnes (Everyone Saw);